

Ambassador Sergio Gor, President Donald Trump and Secretary of State Marco Rubio

> **"You're seeing a level of engagement that is unmatched in terms of US cabinet officials coming to India and ministers going to the US. On his last trip, Secretary Rubio came for four days...and he is coming back in October"**

> **"I am fully confident that we will get a trade deal across the finish line in the next few weeks or months. I will tell people to keep it in perspective: the EU has been working on one for 20-plus years and it is still not done"**

Apache helicopters delivered earlier in the year, or various other items in the works—yes, there is a lot happening in defence sales. But the relationship is also anchored on incredible military exercises. Just a few weeks from now, the largest exercise here in India, Yudh Abhyas, will be happening in Rajasthan. India has more military exercises with the US than any other country. It also comes down to the friendship that our president has with your prime minister. As you saw at the G7 a couple of months ago in France, President Donald Trump was very clear: as long as my friend Prime Minister Narendra Modi is there, India will be able to rely on the US.

Q. What tangible outcomes are we looking at from Secretary of State Marco Rubio's visit in October?
My goal is to ensure that not only the president and the prime minister, but also our ministers are constantly engaged. You're seeing a level of engagement that is unmatched from previous years in terms of cabinet officials coming to India and ministers travelling to the US. On his last trip, Secretary Rubio came for four days, which was his longest trip outside of the US without the president, and he is coming back in October. I had a minister here ask me, "This is very rare that the secretary of state would come twice in such a short time to India." My message to them was very clear: get used to it. We want to have a closer relationship, and that means we have to show up, and vice versa. I anticipate not only Secretary Rubio but also a lot of other cabinet officials. We also have three governors coming here before the end of the year, one a month, from very significant states, because they see the incredible win-win opportunities for the US and India.

> **"India doing well economically is a great thing for us. We want a stable India. A lot of that credit goes to your prime minister. He brings a stability to India that does not exist in other parts of the world"**

Q. When are we going to see a trade deal?
The trade deal is progressing. As you know, within a month of my arriving in India as ambassador, we had announced a trade deal. The Supreme Court unfortunately struck down one of the laws in the US, so we've had to go back and rewrite a lot of that, and it is being rebuilt. I am fully confident that we will get a trade deal across the finish line in the next few weeks or months. I will tell people to keep it in perspective: the European Union has been working on one for 20-plus years and it's still not done. We're way ahead of a lot of other partners. Both sides realise there are incredible opportunities here, and we'll be able to move on it in the very near future.

Q. Foreign minister S. Jaishankar will also be travelling to the US. Can we expect any key bilateral moments at the G20 in December when Prime Minister Modi travels to Florida?
Dr Jaishankar is also one of my favourites. As your question relates to the G20, I don't have specific announcements, but because the president considers the prime minister a friend, I do anticipate there will be more to that visit than just a group meeting. If you had to ask the president, "Hey, you have 35 people coming, who do you want to see?", the prime minister would be at the top of that list.

Q. Looking at the momentum of Indo-US relations, what gives you the highest degree of confidence regarding the direction of the strategic partnership?
The biggest thing that gives me confidence is looking at the numbers, and numbers don't lie. Year after year, our bilateral trade increases, so do our purchases and military exercises. The trajectory of this relationship is on a constant rise. One reason that is happening is because we have two leaders that are result-oriented and move fast. Your prime minister wants to get things done fast, and that is something the president strongly believes in. When those two things align, good things happen.

Q. President Trump is likely to visit India next year. How excited is he to come back?
The president has incredibly fond memories of India. So, stay tuned. That's all I can say. ■